

Their industries, career paths and starting points could hardly be more different. Yet, Sardana and Rangarajan faced a common challenge—turning a business opportunity into an organisation capable of delivering at scale.

That challenge also runs through the experiences of Rithika Mohan, co-founder and chief administrative officer of drone company Garuda Aerospace, and Shilpa Choudari of defence-technology company Zen Technologies, whose career evolved from research and marketing support into finance and operations.

Their journeys offer a view of leadership that goes beyond the familiar founder narrative. In businesses shaped by technological uncertainty, demanding customers and the need to scale, developing teams, establishing processes, allocating responsibility and making difficult decisions can be as consequential as the original innovation.

THE WORK BEHIND SCALE

Rangarajan joined Data Patterns when the company was small enough for many functions to be handled informally. Recruitment, training and administration had to become more structured as the business expanded into increasingly complex electronics. She drew on her experience across psychology, journalism, corporate communications and human resources, including her stint at Polaris Software. The priority was to build practices that employees could understand and own rather than impose procedures to just satisfy external requirements.

The approach to quality certification reflected that philosophy. Teams worked together to document processes, establish checklists and follow procedures before pursuing the relevant certification requirements. "We have to institutionalise whatever we are doing," says Rangarajan. Processes were not paperwork added after growth but part of the intellectual property that allowed the organisation to grow without depending entirely on individual employees, she says. Her responsibilities expanded to include planning and construction of the company's manufacturing facility. That gave her a close understanding of production workflow, equipment and infrastructure needed to build electronic systems. It was also her induction into technology.

At Zen Technologies, too, Choudari's path into leadership was gradual. She started out as a research fellow supporting marketing, moved into marketing and tender-related work, and later took on finance and operations responsibilities. She grew by taking up unfamiliar responsibilities. "I can do much more than what I believe," she says, describing what she learnt as she started meeting people, questioning decisions

Authority must be backed by opportunity. Women still face more pressure to prove capabilities. Need for fairer assessments and access to decision-making roles

The interviews reveal how women can feel immense pressure to prove readiness before being trusted

Lasting change requires translating women's growing participation into meaningful leadership, influence and opportunities